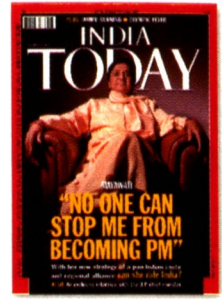


MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



"Mayawati",

August 18, 2008

"Mayawati can be crude, abusive and arbitrary in her approach which has helped her antagonise the political alignment. She is an attractive proposition, no doubt."

ROSHAN AGRAWAL, on e-mail

Queen M

For most of us, the question is not whether Mayawati can become the prime minister, but whether she should ("No One Can Stop Me From Becoming PM", August 18). But before that, she needs to shed her parochial vision, personal vendetta, narcissism and self-hallucination. India needs a prime minister capable of reining in terrorism and internal insurgency, maintaining high economic growth with equitable distribution of wealth and taking India to glorious heights.

Y.G. CHOUKSEY, Pune

Mayawati's meteoric rise is truly astounding. She has evolved a lot as a person and politician, and now she is poised to take up the premiership of the country at an opportune time. Her growing popularity has, no doubt, sent alarming sig-

nals in the corridors of power. To become the prime minister, she needs to play her cards well. This Dalit's daughter has the potential to script another glorious chapter in the history of politics.

VIRENDRA KUMAR TANGRI,
on e-mail

Mayawati is an opportunist who is eminently unsuitable for the country's top post. She lacks the gumption to stay clean in the office. She is manipulative in her moves and knows how to make friends to suit her convenience. Allies like N. Chandrababu Naidu, Om Prakash Chautala, K. Chandrashekhar Rao, Ajit Singh and the emaciated Communists like Prakash Karat and Co may have kickstarted Maya-for-Prime Minister call but it's too simplistic on their part, to argue along the lines of the staid political arithmetic, to catapult her to the coveted position.

Maya is a supercilious simpleton, who is brazenly moving ahead to fulfil her ambitions to become what she aspires, but unfortunately doesn't deserve.

KARANAM RAO, Hyderabad

In the cover story ("Can She Rule India?", August 18), an erroneous impression has been created in the subtext titled "Maya Durbar" that the chief minister has delegated all administrative decision-making responsibilities to Cabinet Secretary Shashank S. Singh and does not take interest in her administrative chores. It may be mentioned that the cabinet secretary is one of the many senior bureaucrats who aid and advise the chief minister in her duties. Ms. Mayawati has been the chief minister on four occasions in the last 13 years and, hence, she is fully aware of her responsibilities as the administrative and constitutional head

of government. As an astute administrator, the chief minister keeps in mind the 'strengths' of individual officers while assigning work to them. Hence, it is incorrect to single out any one officer from the chief minister's secretariat like Shailesh Krishna, principal secretary, for 'special mention'. Likewise, it is the work of the chief minister which builds her image rather than the 'doings' of any particular bureaucrat like Navneet Sehgal, secretary. Ms. Mayawati, chief minister of Uttar Pradesh and BSP president, does not require a 'hit man' or the networking skills of any bureaucrat or political figure to further her political goals.

VIJAY SHANKAR PANDEY,
Principal Secretary,
Information Department,
Uttar Pradesh Government

Just because Mayawati got her arithmetic right in